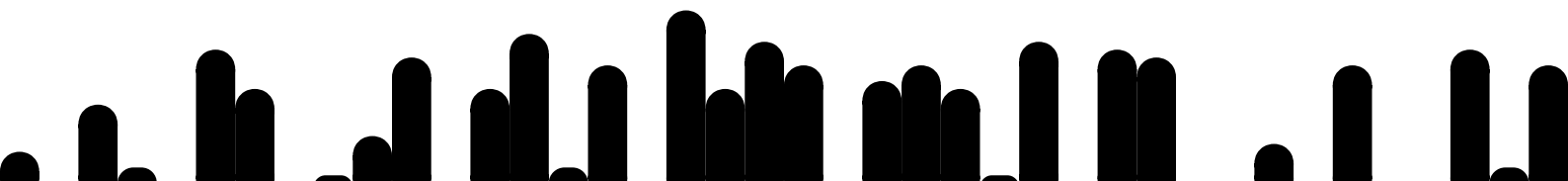


Embodiment

Roll, Create, Characterise - Your Journey Begins!



Introduction

The Embodiment Game is a role-playing design tool that helps participants explore how users interact with devices in real-world contexts. Through structured roleplay and reflection, it enables designers to better understand usability challenges, accessibility issues, and unintended interactions.

Purpose and Learning Objectives

- 01.** Encourage empathy in design through user perspective roleplay.
- 02.** Identify and analyze both intended and unintended interactions.
- 03.** Strengthen the ability to design for diverse user needs and constraints
- 04.** Facilitate critical reflection on design decisions.

Who is this Game For?

This game is intended for:

- + Design students exploring user interaction.
- + UX and industrial designers refining product usability.
- + Educators and facilitators teaching human-centered design principles.
- + Anyone interested in designing better, more inclusive products.

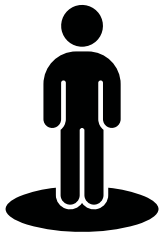
Game Setup

Before diving into gameplay, it's essential to set up the game space and understand each player's role. The Embodiment Game is designed to be flexible, allowing for quick setup while ensuring an engaging and reflective experience.

This section outlines the materials needed, the role distribution, and how to create an environment that fosters meaningful interaction and observation.

Player Roles Overview

Each round involves three roles:



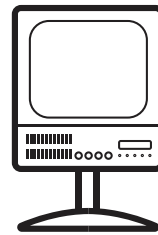
User

Plays a randomly generated character archetype.



Designer

Defines the device and context.



Device

Acts according to the designer's specified constraints.

Required Materials

- + Printed Role Cards
- + Wildcard Decks (Environment, Emotional States, Device Interrupts)
- + Dice for determining user traits
- + Whiteboard or notepad for observations
- + Reflection Worksheets

Setting Up the Game Space

01. Arrange participants so the User and Device can interact easily.
02. Ensure Designers have a clear view to observe and take notes.
03. Provide enough space to allow for movement and roleplay.

Gameplay Overview

The game takes place over several rounds where players take on the roles of **Designer, User, and Device** to explore how design decisions impact real-world interactions.

This section provides an overview of the game's core mechanics, the flow of each round, and how different elements, such as role cards, wildcard modifiers, and structured reflection, contribute to the learning experience.

Core Mechanics

The Embodiment Game is built around role-based interaction, where players embody different perspectives to explore the intended and unintended consequences of design decisions in real time

01. Players rotate through the roles over three rounds.
02. Users roll to determine their personality and impairment.
03. Designers observe and document interactions.

Using Role Cards, Wildcards, and Impairments

The game uses a variety of cards to shape interactions, challenge assumptions, and introduce unexpected elements.

04. Role Cards define player responsibilities
05. Wildcards add unexpected challenges to interactions.
06. Impairments simulate real-world accessibility challenges.

Three-Round Structure

Each game session consists of three rounds, allowing every player to experience the roles of Designer, User, and Device, ensuring a well-rounded understanding of interaction challenges and design impact.

- + Round 1: Standard interaction scenario
- + Round 2: Additional challenges introduced via Wildcards.
- + Round 3: Extreme or unexpected interaction conditions.

Roles

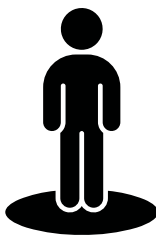
Players take on distinct roles that shape the way interactions unfold. Each round, participants rotate between being the **Designer**, **User**, and **Device**, gaining a unique perspective on how products are used, perceived, and constrained. These roles encourage players to step into different mindsets, challenge assumptions, and observe the real-world impact of design decisions. Understanding the responsibilities and challenges of each role is key to making the most of the game experience.



Designer Role

The Designer defines the intended function and interaction of the device, setting constraints and observing how users engage with their creation.

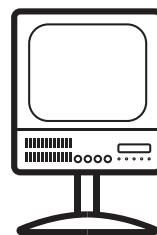
- + Defines device characteristics
- + Observes user interactions.
- + Analyses intended vs. actual use.



User Role

The User interacts with the device while embodying a specific character archetype, revealing usability challenges and unexpected behaviours.

- + Embodies a randomly assigned character.
- + Interacts with the device naturally
- + Provides feedback on the experience.



Device Role

The Device follows the Designer's instructions, acting as the interface between the User and the system, demonstrating both intended functionality and limitations.

- + Acts as the device based on designer instructions.
- + Responds realistically to user input
- + Simulates both functional and dysfunctional states.

Character Creation

Character creation in the Embodiment Game involves three key elements: Archetypes, Personality Traits, and Impairments. These combinations help shape the user's interaction style and create varied scenarios.

Rolling for Character

Archetypes

Players roll a die to determine their Character Archetype, which represents the user's general approach to interaction (e.g., The Leader, The Innovator, The Explorer).

Example Character Combinations

01. The Idealist + Skeptical + Limited Dexterity – A thoughtful but hesitant user struggling with fine motor control.
02. The Diplomat + Impulsive + No Impairment – A smooth talker who makes rash decisions.

Rolling for Personality Traits

A second roll assigns a Personality Trait that further defines how the user behaves (e.g., Stubborn, Curious, Agreeable).

Rolling for Impairments

A final roll determines whether the user has an impairment affecting the interaction (e.g., Limited Dexterity, Low Vision, No Impairment).

Wildcard Modifiers

Wildcard Modifiers introduce unexpected elements to challenge interactions. They are drawn at the start of each round and may be blank or introduce environmental, emotional, or device-based constraints.

Environment Modifier Deck

These cards, used by the designer, introduce external conditions that impact how the User interacts with the Device, such as poor lighting, noisy surroundings, or time constraints. They highlight how context shapes user experience.

These cards are visible to all players when played.

Emotional States Deck

These cards, played by the user, define the User's emotional mindset, such as frustration, excitement, or hesitation, influencing how they approach the interaction and revealing how emotional factors affect usability.

These cards are only visible to the user when played.

Device Interrupt Deck

These cards introduce functional quirks or limitations to the Device, such as unresponsive buttons, slow response time, or unexpected errors, simulating real-world design challenges and constraints.

These cards are only visible to the device when played.

Using Blank Cards

Blank cards are included in each deck to introduce an element of unpredictability and realism into the game. When drawn, they signify that no additional constraints, emotions, or interruptions are applied, allowing for unmodified interactions. This ensures that not every round is influenced by external factors, making the game flow more dynamic and encouraging players to observe the natural interactions between the Designer, User, and Device without imposed challenges.

Playing the Game

The **Embodiment Game** is an interactive experience that unfolds through a structured sequence of actions, guiding players through real-time user interactions and design evaluations. Each round presents new challenges, shaped by role assignments, wildcard modifiers, and the dynamics of the group. This section provides a clear step-by-step guide to ensure smooth gameplay, helping players navigate their roles effectively and make the most of each interaction.

Step-by-Step Guide

Round 1: Establishing the Core Interaction

This round sets the initial control interaction. The Designer directs both the User and the Device, establishing the conditions of the interaction.

01. The Designer defines the device and its constraints. The Device receives its characteristics—these are hidden from the User.
02. The User is given a task to achieve, hidden from the Device.
03. The User rolls the dice to determine their archetype, personality trait, and impairment.
04. No wildcards are drawn this round.
05. The User interacts with the Device, while the Device responds based on its defined characteristics.
06. If needed, the Designer can direct the interaction, ensuring clarity.
07. The Designer takes notes on expected vs. actual interactions.
08. At the end of the round, each player completes the Quick Reflection Worksheet.

Round 2: Introducing Complexity

This round adds external influences, challenging the interaction with environmental, emotional, or device-based constraints.

01. Each player draws a wildcard from their deck, introducing new constraints that modify the interaction. The **Designer** should show their card and the **User** and **Device** should keep theirs hidden.
02. The Designer redefines any necessary conditions based on the wildcard's impact.
03. The User interacts with the Device, adapting to the newly introduced challenge.
04. The Designer observes and records unintended consequences.
05. The round concludes with a brief discussion, focusing on how the wildcard affected usability. Players complete the Quick Reflection Worksheet.

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Structured Reflection Round

Reflection is a critical component of the game allowing participants to distill insights from their interactions and explore how products shape and respond to user experiences.

By analysing how context, emotional states, and unexpected challenges influenced interactions, you will develop a deeper understanding of human-centred design. This reflection round encourages participants to examine what worked, what failed, and why.

Revealing design opportunities that may not be obvious in traditional ideation processes the structured discussion allows players to refine their designs to make intuitive and socially intelligent products.

Step 1: Initial Reactions

Each player provides a brief first impression of how the interaction went.

Before diving into deeper analysis, take a moment to reflect on the interaction that just took place. Consider what felt natural, what was challenging, and any unexpected outcomes that emerged.

This reflection should take part after every interaction round

Step 2: In-Depth

Reflection

Now that all rounds are complete, take a step back to analyse the broader patterns and insights from the game. This discussion goes beyond individual interactions to explore how context, emotional states, and product constraints shaped user experiences. Consider recurring challenges, unexpected behaviours, and opportunities for improving product interactions. This deeper reflection will help translate game findings into actionable design strategies.

01. **User Perspective:** What felt intuitive or frustrating?
02. **Device Perspective:** Did the Device function as expected?
03. **Designer Perspective:** Were there unintended consequences?

Step 3: Key Takeaways

Using the Reflection Cards, revisit your experiences across all three roles. Compare insights, identify recurring patterns, and discuss how different factors shaped interactions. This final reflection helps translate gameplay into actionable design strategies.

- + The Designer from the final round draws 3–4 Reflection Cards for the group.
- + Draw cards one at a time, discussing each prompt thoroughly before moving to the next.
- + Reflect on patterns, unexpected insights, and key takeaways that can inform real-world design decisions.

By the end of this step, participants should have a deeper understanding of how context, emotions, and constraints influence user interactions.

